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Internship terrains: Psychogeographically mapping place

ABSTRACT

Art teacher candidates, recently beginning their internships/student teaching experiences, engaged in a form of arts-based educational research (ABER) to examine their larger teaching contexts – the communities surrounding their placement schools – through a performance-based, map-based approach. Much like the Situationists' psychogeographies of the 1950s and 1960s, where artist geographers wandered the urban landscapes in attempts to construct interpretive readings of well-known European cities, interns began by playfully 'drifting' through the geographic environments of their school zones. Through the act of drifting, interns conducted enquiries into their own sense of place. 'Maps' of place embodied these explorations and discoveries. Such explorations of place are vital as educators seek to construct rich understandings of their students' lived worlds and to provide appropriate, relevant learning experiences. This visual essay explores the value and possibilities of one ABER approach for teacher education.

KEYWORDS

arts-based educational research
teacher education
art education
mapping
sense of place
psychogeography

INTRODUCTION

University of Tennessee pre-service art teachers have varying degrees of knowledge of the schools and communities where they are placed for their yearlong internships (i.e., student teaching experiences). Some have known these communities since birth, while others from distant parts of the state have little familiarity with the neighbourhoods surrounding their placement schools. These interns need to develop knowledge of their teaching context quickly – particularly the larger context of the community – if they hope to gain a deep, embodied understanding of their students' lived experiences, to connect their teaching to these experiences (Johnson 2002) and to open opportunities for community-based and place-based approaches to learning.

Arts-based educational research (ABER) offered such an opportunity. As acts of ABER, interns engaged in psychogeography and mapping to enquire into their larger teaching contexts. Within the field of teacher education, mapping has been used with pre-service teachers to include the creation of 'rhizomatic' cartographies of teacher education experiences (Hofsess 2015: 1) and the documentation of student teaching experiences in urban schools (Sutters 2012). Additionally, the Situationists' method of psychogeographical wandering (O'Rourke 2013) has been appropriated in recent years for a range of activities, including art activism (Souzis 2015), social and spatial experimentation (Enigbokan 2014) and feminist geography (Bridger 2013) – all with the intent of enhancing participant perception and formulating new narratives within urban spaces.

Much like the Situationists' driftings of the 1950s and 1960s (O'Rourke 2013), interns began by engaging in firsthand, sensory, mindful experiences of place as they wandered in pairs through their school zones. They reflected individually on their findings in visual verbal journals, amalgams of text and imagery (Hofsess 2015). Interns then embarked on the journey of visually representing their experiences and reflections through maps of place. The works of Joyce Kozloff and Lordy Rodriguez served as illustrations of cartography employed for metaphoric means (Marshall 2014). Interns shared insights from the ABER process through a class presentation of maps. Quotes from discussions and journal entries are interwoven in this visual essay as a means to illuminate the possibilities of one ABER approach to fostering sense of place.

ATTENDING TO AESTHETICS



Figure 1: Karns (2015), Mixed media.

It feels warm and friendly, and it feels consistent.

It's a simple, small town. It's pleasant, chill, not too busy.

The community is spread out. There's room for green things.



Figure 2: Fountain City (2015), Watercolour.

I used watercolour because it's a soft, clean area.

Lots of green space.

It's tucked away. It's bright. It's nice. You go down Broadway, and then you are like, 'Oh, it's nice over here'.

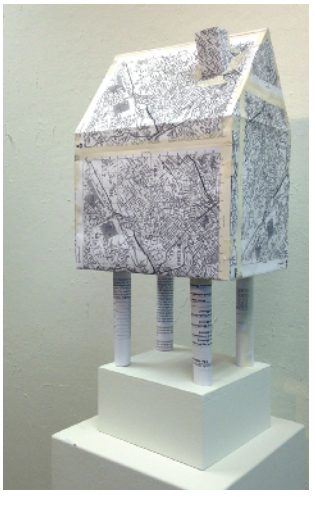


Figure 3: East Knoxville (2015), Mixed media.

I've got the other side of the tracks

Some students walk to school, but there is no crosswalk.

No green space,

Few parks.

IDENTIFYING COMMUNITY ASSETS



Figure 4: South Knoxville (2015), Mixed media.

[Prior to the experience] South Knoxville was kind of dirty to me.

On Chapman Highway, there's [sic] a lot of empty buildings boarded up. What we realized is how beautiful that area can be…

The Ijams Nature Center,

The Island Home Airport,

The historic neighbourhoods.

South Knoxville [represents] pockets of beauty in nature masked by old, commercialized areas and a lot of bad fast food.

EXAMINING THE DEVELOPED ENVIRONMENT AND CONSIDERING ISSUES OF CLASS



Figure 5: Corryton (2015), Mixed media.

It's rural. It's beautiful. It's a nice area. Everything is really spread out. There's an intersection and that's pretty much it.

I expected Gibbs kids to be more 'Southern' than they are, but only [sic] few kids are 'farmers'.



Figure 6: Cedar Bluff (2015), Mixed media.

We first drove through the Cedar Bluff shopping centre. It's very crowded with well-known restaurants and stores. It has a lot going on…

I focused on the roads and the lines they make on the map.

It's suburban roads based on the curves.

I painted a house in one of the neighborhoods.

The houses were in nice neighborhoods. They were larger, two-story houses with large yards.

Our student population is… middle class.

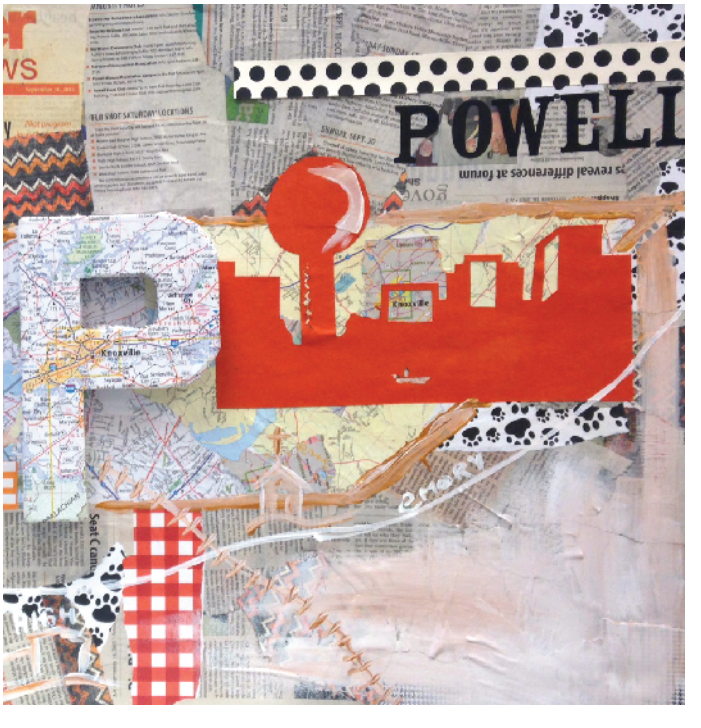
GAUGING SENSE OF COMMUNITY

It's disjointed.

It's a melting pot of different cultures, but the cultures aren't visible – their identity is not part of the community. There's no strong community identity.

The school holds together the community. They almost shut down the school a few years ago. They raised money for it.

The school is important to the community. It's a real pillar.



There's a good sense of community and being involved. The paw print stands for the Powell Panthers. On Friday nights everyone will go to support the kids and the community.

A lot of people that work there, went there.

People were raised in the community.

Figure 7: Powell (2015), Mixed media.



Figure 8: Oak Ridge (2015), Mixed media.

Oak Ridge – I'm from there. I still have family there. 'Atomic City' is down front. The city is proud of [that status]. There are still guard towers at the entrance to the city that you can still see. It's still a secret city. No one knows [the different features of the community] unless they go there and get shown around.



Figure 9: Downtown Knoxville (2015), Mixed media.

It's a lottery school. People are drawn there because it's a STEM school. [It] bring[s] people from all over Knox County. I don't think of them as a specific community because they are from all over.

These students, they've created their own community here – a community of acceptance. It's hard to put into words. You will just have to visit one day.

CONCLUSION



Figure 10: Sequoyah Hills (2015), Tempera.

Sequoyah is gorgeous – a picturesque neighbourhood. [On the trip], I took a pic of a house with a mailbox. The mailbox was bigger than my bathroom.

Sometimes it's easy to teach to those students. Sometimes the others are in the corner. That's not what I want to do.

Barone and Eisner claimed arts-based research 'heightens our consciousness to aspects of the world' and allows us to 'notice relationships that might not otherwise be seen' (2011: 159–60). By attending to the specificity of place, interns emerged with revitalized perception. Many maps invited multiple readings as interns engaged with the complexities of place that surfaced. For instance, in the map above, issues of class, geography and educational inequality intersect. This intern, in particular, moved beyond describing the spatiality of place as she interrogated her own role in perpetuating or disrupting existing hierarchies. She began to uncover oppression and transform praxis. Through the act of drifting, new dialogues and consciousness took shape.

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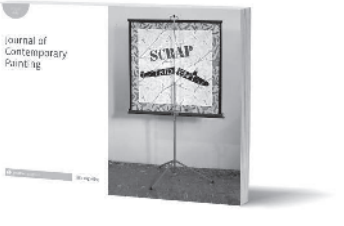
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